Wiebelskirchen. He bragged how, years later, a local resident told West German television he had admired the mettle of the young KPD campaigner: ‘Honecker told me that this was his conviction, and it did not require special courage.’10 In the end, the morale of communist activists was dealt a bitter blow when voters opted for unification with Hitler’s Germany on 13 January 1935 – making the KPD in Saarland an illegal entity. ‘The referendum result turned out even worse than I had expected,’ Honecker lamented.11 ‘Of the 540,000 voters, supposedly 470,000 voted for the return to Germany and only 4,000 for the status quo.’12

As Nazi muscles arrived in the Saarland, Honecker was deployed north to the Ruhr with the approval of the Saar KVJD. After receiving 180 Francs and being installed in a safe house in Essen, he set about making a personal investigation of attitudes towards the Reichsarbeitsdienst (the official state labour service) and compiled a report on mining conditions and unemployment in the district. Unaware he had been under police surveillance, he was forced to abandon his work after being arrested in Gelsenkirchen, north of Essen, on 15 February, after being detained outside a cinema under the pretext of suspected theft. ‘As Honecker presumed that his arrest had to do with his political activity, he left the same day for Saarbrucken,’ a police report noted.13

Unnerved by what was happening, he briefly visited Forbach in the Moselle on 27 February, before steaming unmolested into the Gare Montparnasse in Paris where he brooded for several weeks until the KPD in exile instructed him to lead Communist Youth League activities in Berlin, a role which required a new identity. His mission was to replace Bruno Baum, who was preparing to flee into exile because of his Jewish faith. ‘I had to change by gradual stages into the sailor Martin Tjaden, born 21 September 1911 in Amsterdam, living in Amsterdam,’ Honecker explained. A passport photograph was taken in Paris, and he received a Dutch passport in Switzerland. Via Basel, he journeyed to Zurich. ‘Then I moved on, from Switzerland via Austria and Czechoslovakia.’ By the time he reached Berlin during the blistering August of 1935, anti-communist purges had swept through the entire city which was in the midst of a beautification campaign for the 1936 Olympics. Baum briefed his replacement on the status of underground KJVD work and gave pointers on how to percolate with